The Subarctic

The subarctic region is comprised of mostly Canada, inland Alaska and the tundra. The region features swampy pine forests known as taiga. Those who live in the Subarctic region have been separated by scholars in to two language groups. The first are known as the Algonquian speakers found in the east, which include the Naskapi, the Ojibwa and the Cree. The second are Athabaskan speakers in the west, which include the Deg Xinag, the Kuchin and the Tsattine.

Travelling across this region has always been extremely challenging. Those who travelled frequently used kayaks, snowshoes and toboggans. The population here is much lower than in other cultural regions and is scattered across the territory. Most of the population stayed in family units instead of forming larger and stable settlements. They lived in portable tents and structures that could be transported as they followed the caribou herds. When the weather grew too cold to live in tents, they created warmer shelters by digging trenches.

During the 1600s and the 1700s, the fur trade grew dramatically and had a deep impact on the lifestyle of the nomadic families who lived in the region. The natives relied on hunting to feed themselves and their families. As time passed, they began to rely heavily on trading furs with the early European settlers to survive. Unfortunately, this led to local societies being displaced and many were killed from the diseases that the Europeans had introduced to the region.